demic was still raging, after a tenure of just two years. To ensure the continued support of the state's powerful Lingayat cohort, the BJP made Basavaraj Bommai, another Lingayat leader, the chief minister. With Bommai's clean image and reputation of being an able administrator, Surjewala realised they had a fight on their hands. "We need to hammer Bommai down before he becomes a giant; otherwise, we will be dead," he apparently told his team.

LESSON 2: CASH IN ON CORRUPTION

The opportunity to put Bommai on the mat presented itself months after he took over as chief minister. In November 2021, the Karnataka Contractors' Association released a letter it had written to the Prime Minister's Office in which it made the striking allegation that bills amounting to Rs 17,000 crore for government projects remained unpaid and complained of "rampant corruption", including having to pay bribes of up to 40 per cent to win tenders and get their bills passed.

THE CONGRESS DECIDED THAT THE BJP WOULD PLAY ON THE PITCH THAT IT LAID OUT. IT BATTED ON THE FRONT FOOT

More was to follow. Another contractor, Santosh Patil, in a separate letter to the PMO, alleged that rural development minister K.S. Eshwarappa had demanded a 40 per cent commission from him to clear a bill worth Rs 4 crore for road construction undertaken in Belagavi the same year. Months later, in April 2022, Patil would die by suicide, but not before sending out a WhatsApp message to his friends blaming the minister for forcing him to take the step. Eshwarappa was forced to resign soon after.

Sensing the opportunity, Surjewala, who happened to be in the state for a party function, cancelled the event and asked Shivakumar and the local Congress MLAs to go down to Belagavi and meet Patil's widow, handing her a cheque of Rs 11 lakh from the party's coffers even as another MLA donated an additional Rs 5 lakh. The Congress then decided to



READING THE VOTE

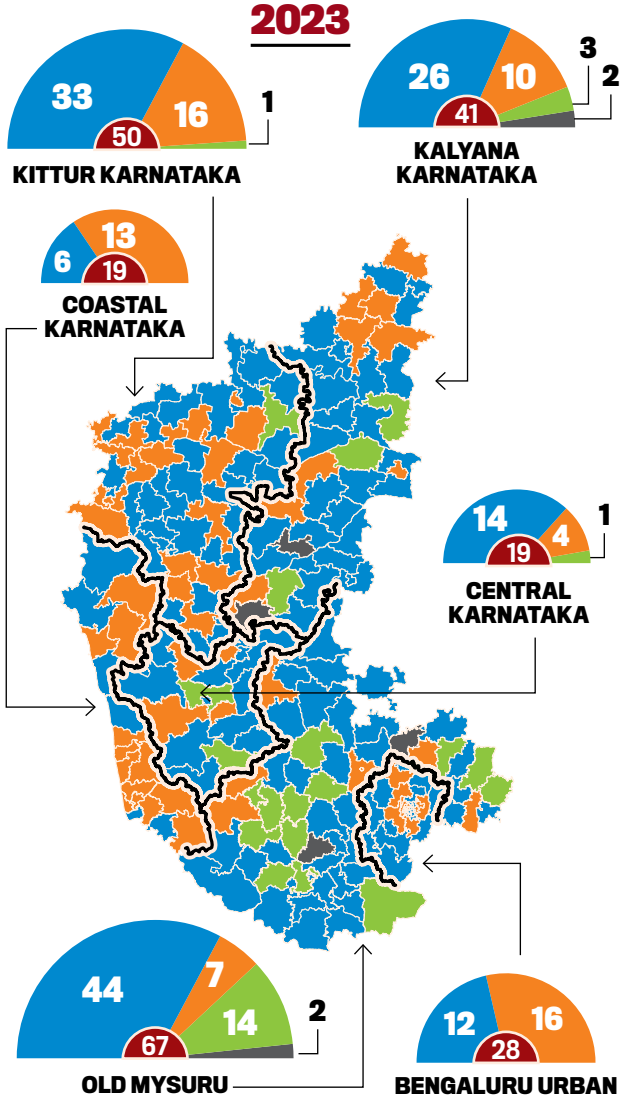
BOTH THE FINAL NUMBERS AND THE EXIT POLL REPORT THROW UP INTERESTING INSIGHTS ON HOW KARNATAKA VOTED

BJP CONGRESS JD(S) OTHERS

REGION-WISE SEATS

THE ZONAL SPLIT

Barring Bengaluru Urban, the Congress improved its seat tally across Karnataka



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